advanced north of Granada, taking Ubeda, Baeza, and Almería from Alfonso's very hands.[3]

On the way home from the defeat at Almería, Alfonso VII fell ill. He died in August of 1157, leaving Castile and León in the hands of his two sons Sancho and Fernando.

The division of the kingdom set the two brothers and their heirs against each other, severing the last unity among the four Christian kingdoms. Sancho died after a single year on the throne of Castile, and his three-year-old son Alfonso VIII inherited it, plunging Castile into a struggle between noble families for control of the regency; the king of Navarre, son of Garcia the Restorer, took advantage of Castile's weakness to claim a few border towns for himself.[4]



13.1 The Kingdoms of Spain

But the Muslims in the south were on no better terms than the Christians of the north. Spain remained a secondary priority for the Almohad caliph, who was still shoring up his hold on North Africa. Granada had surrendered, but Ibn Mardanish of Valencia and Murcia refused to submit to Almohad rule, holding on to his alliance with the Christians of Castile instead; and Granada was constantly on the edge of rebellion against Almohad domination.[5]

Many of the peoples living in the contested and chaotic areas fled. Among them was Rabbi Maimon ben Joseph, who in 1160 took his wife and grown children and left the peninsula. Like many other Jews, the ben Joseph family had been living under steadily worsening conditions. An Almohad decree in